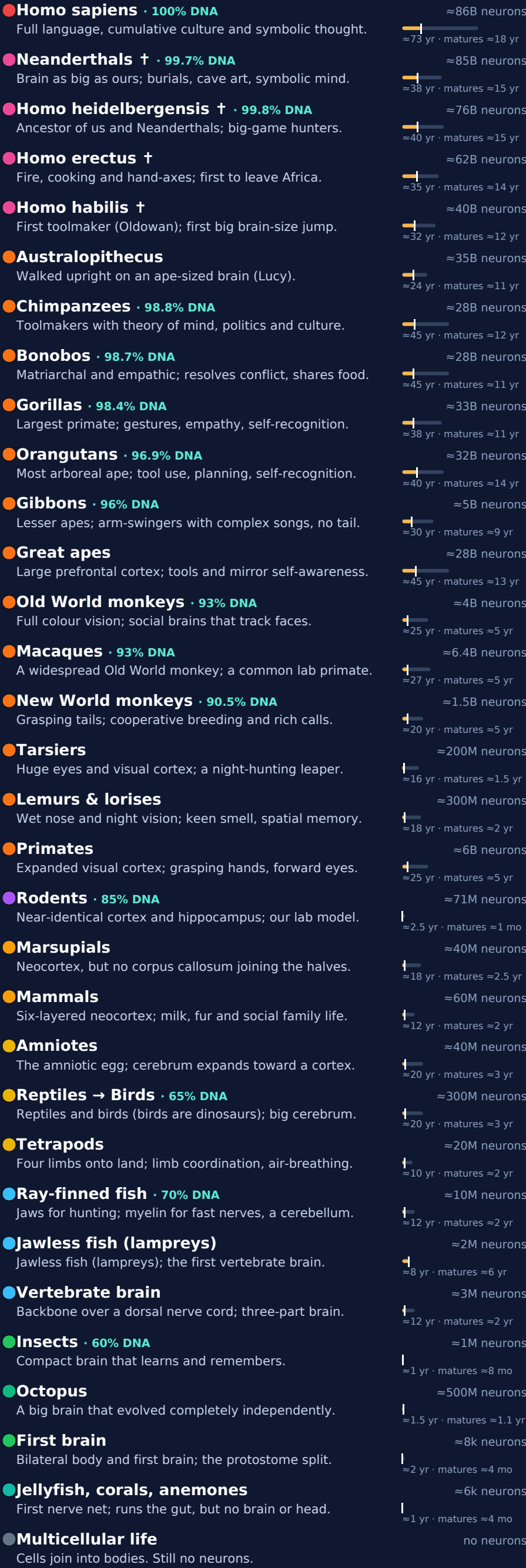
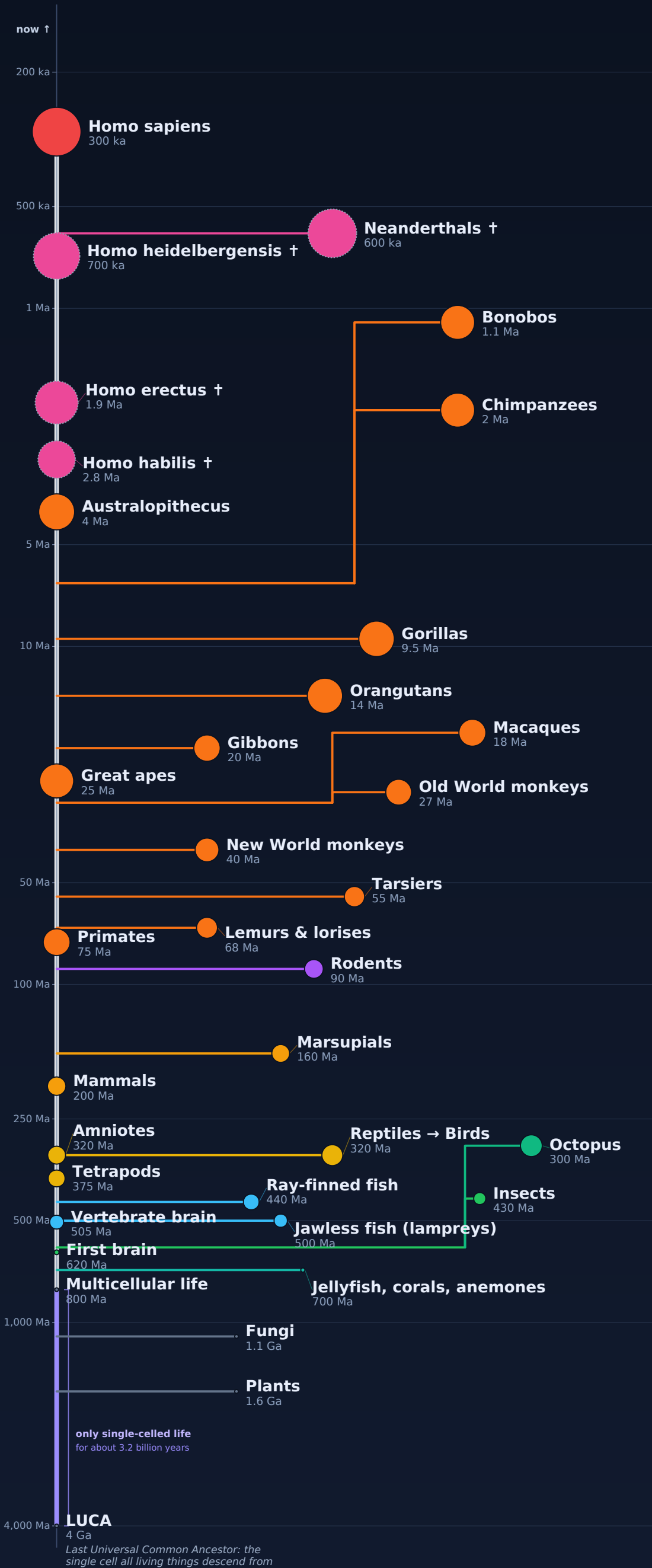


The Nervous System's Family Tree



How to read this diagram

The tree and time scale

The vertical axis is time on a logarithmic scale (Ma = million, Ga = billion years ago). Recent events near the top get more room; older ones compress toward the bottom. The pale central line is your own lineage, and each branch peels off where that group last shared an ancestor with you. Split-times sit under every name. The purple stretch marks the ~3.2 billion years when life was still only single-celled. A cross or dashed circle marks an extinct lineage.

The dots: colour = group

Colour = group or lineage; size = log(neurons).

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| <div></div> Humans (Homo sapiens) | <div></div> Fish / early vertebrates |
| <div></div> Other Homo species | <div></div> Octopus (convergent) |
| <div></div> Primates & apes | <div></div> Insects & first brains |
| <div></div> Rodents | <div></div> Nerve net, no brain |
| <div></div> Mammals | <div></div> No neurons |
| <div></div> Reptiles & birds | |

The bars: life history

In the key on the right, each bar is one lifetime drawn to scale in years, so a longer bar means a longer life. The gold part is the time spent reaching maturity, which shows what fraction of life is spent growing up. Octopus, lamprey and insects grow almost their whole lives; rodents grow up in a flash.

gold = years to maturity, tick = adulthood